1989 Zarb-i-Momim military exercise, the largest in Pakistan's history, did not return to their peacetime stations; they lingered near the international border and the LOC in Kashmir. The Indians feared that these movements were designed to support terrorist operations within Indian territory. Meanwhile, in February, two Indian armored units deployed to a firing range in Rajasthan. The Pakistanis worried that these forces could form the nucleus of a large-scale Indian attack.[24]

This cycle of military action and reaction touched off a series of heated exchanges in the press between Indian and Pakistani leaders. In mid-March, Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto, during a visit to Pakistani Kashmir, announced the Pakistan was prepared for "one thousand years of war with Hindu India" in pursuit of Kashmiri freedom from Indian rule. Indian prime minister V. P. Singh, in an early April speech to the Lok Sabha, responded, "I warn them [that] those who talk about a thousand years of war should examine whether they will last [for] a thousand hours of war."[25]

By mid-April, roughly two hundred thousand army and paramilitary forces were deployed in Indian Kashmir, where they faced approximately a hundred thousand troops across the LOC in Pakistani Kashmir. Indian leaders feared that Pakistani forces could sever lines of communication between Punjab and Kashmir, and aid the Kashmiri insurgency. The Pakistanis, for their part, worried that India might launch a major armored thrust in Sindh or raid insurgent camps in Pakistani Kashmir.[26]

The unfolding events caught the attention of the U.S. government and in mid-May, U.S. deputy national security adviser Robert Gates traveled to Islamabad and New Delhi. Gates urged restraint on Pakistani and Indian leaders. He informed both sides that while India would likely win any full-scale Indo-Pakistani war, victory would be exceedingly costly. He secured a promise from Pakistani officials to close training camps for the Kashmiri insurgents and conveyed this news to the Indians. Gates also offered to provide India and Pakistan with satellite reconnaissance data to reassure each side that the other was withdrawing from its forward positions. The crisis deescalated soon after the Gates mission. India announced the return of its forward-deployed armor to its peacetime stations and